

TURN DOWN THE MOON

VOICE-OVER RECORDING SCRIPT

One voice. 27 lines, about 213 words, across three minutes. The sparseness is deliberate – the film's argument is carried by music and by a number on screen driven by real crowd telemetry. The long silences are written in, not gaps waiting to be filled.

The speaker is the antagonist: the author of the argument for turning celebration down to a safe level. He is narrating in retrospect, to someone he assumes agrees with him, and he believes he is the reasonable party.

SMUG, NOT JACKBOOTED. Warm, unhurried, faintly amused, completely certain. Never angry, never menacing, never camp. A senior public-health official who is pleased to explain something to you and has never been contradicted. The film only works if his case genuinely lands.

Record dry: 48kHz 24-bit mono WAV, no processing of any kind. One file per line, named by its number. Three reads of each – as written, warmer, drier – in the same file. Plus thirty seconds of clean room tone as its own file.

ACT I	THE FLATLINE	0:00–0:35	6 lines
ACT II	THE RITUAL	0:35–1:05	5 lines
ACT III	THE SIGNAL SPREADS	1:05–1:35	5 lines
ACT IV	THE SOFTENING	1:35–2:24	9 lines
ACT V	THE ANSWER	2:24–3:00	2 lines

Full direction notes: docs/vo-script.md
github.com/fractastical/turn-down-the-moon

ACT I – THE FLATLINE 0:00–0:35

- 1** 0:02.0 You will have noticed that it is quieter now.
Opening the film. Almost pleasant.
- 2** 0:11.0 Everyone is allocated what they need.
Flat. A statement of policy, not a defence.
- 3** 0:15.5 This is what a safe evening looks like.
Over an empty surveillance wall. He means it.
- 4** 0:20.5 Nobody is hurt. Nobody is missing. Nobody is over-stimulated.
Three beats, equal weight. The third should land as naturally as the first two – that's the joke, and he doesn't know it's one.
- 5** 0:25.0 I wrote the paper on it.
He is on screen here. Not boastful. A small, satisfied fact.
- 6** 0:31.5 We used to look up at the same thing. Once.
The only line in Act I with any wistfulness. Sets up the title.

ACT II – THE RITUAL 0:35–1:05

- 7** 0:36.5 They still gather. I find that touching.
Genuinely touched. No irony on "touching".
- 8** 0:41.0 They bring instruments now. They measure themselves.
First flicker of the thesis. Slight puzzlement.
- 9** 0:46.0 They believe that if enough of them feel it at the same moment, something happens.
Long line, plenty of room. Let it be a little fond.
- 10** 0:54.5 Something does happen. That was never in dispute.
Important: he concedes this completely. No sarcasm – he is not disputing that it works.
- 11** 1:01.9 And then they do the fatal thing. They score it.
The hinge of his whole case. "Fatal" said lightly, almost regretfully.

ACT III – THE SIGNAL SPREADS 1:05–1:35

12 1:06.0 Look at them. Genuinely – look.

An invitation. He thinks he's showing you evidence.

1:10.3–1:13.5 – silence –

The transformation. Nothing over it.

13 1:13.8 Whatever that is, they made it themselves.

A concession he doesn't notice he's making.

14 1:22.2 Ninety-six decibels. In a residential district.

Purely administrative. This is the coldest line in the film and it must be read as the dullest.

15 1:28.2 By morning it was in four cities.

Something has changed. Not alarm – attention.

16 1:31.0 And still nobody could tell me what it was for.

The first crack. Faint irritation, quickly controlled.

ACT IV – THE SOFTENING 1:35–2:24

- 17** 1:35.7 So we made a decision.
He is on screen. Unremarkable, like minuting a meeting.
- 18** 1:38.3 Nobody was arrested. I would like that on the record.
Slight pride. He thinks this is the humane part, and by his lights it is.
- 19** 1:42.7 We were like you. We ran hot.
Warmest line in the film. On screen he is holding up his own book. Almost affectionate – he is offering them his biography as proof he understands.
- 20** 1:45.5 We only asked them to bring it down.
Reasonable. Wounded, even, that this became a fight.
- 21** 1:49.4 You are not enjoying this. Your own instrument agrees.
The film's central line. Said kindly – as a diagnosis being broken gently to a patient. It is devastating precisely because it isn't cruel.
- 22** 1:54.0 They kept dancing. In the dark. Which we had not modelled.
The one place the mask slips. The first two sentences are observation. The third is the sound of a man discovering his model was wrong and reaching for procedural language to cover it. Do not editorialise – just let the last clause sit slightly apart.

ACT IV – THE SOFTENING 1:35–2:24

23 1:58.5 So we removed the supply.

On the shot of a hand pulling the breaker. Absolutely neutral. The euphemism does the work; do not lean on it.

24 2:02.0 And the record of it.

Quieter. An afterthought, which is the point – the deletion matters less to him than the decision did.

2:06.8 – silence –

He salutes and walks out on screen. No line.

25 2:09.2 It is not cruelty. It is arithmetic.

His summation, over the screens dying. Calm and, to him, self-evidently true.

2:14.9–2:24.3 – silence –

The residue and the aftermath. Nine and a half seconds with no voice and almost no score. Do not fill this.

ACT V – THE ANSWER 2:24–3:00

26 2:24.5 There was nothing left. I checked.

Said with total confidence – and the counter starts climbing off zero under it. He is contradicted inside his own sentence.

2:29–2:49 – silence –

Twenty seconds. The film answers him with pictures and music. Nothing over it.

27 2:49.5 We will need to do something about the moon.

The last line. He has learned nothing and the logic doesn't stop – it just moves up a scale. Read it exactly like line 2: a small administrative note to himself. No wink. It is funnier and worse if he means it.

2:54.4 – silence –

Title card. Clean.